CAPYBARA

Hydrochoerus hydrochaeris

Think About This

If you could stay calm around almost any

What can it see, hear, or feel?

Its eyes sit high, its ears pick up soft splashes, and its nose knows every friend in the group.

Where does it live — and why?

It lives near rivers and flooded grasslands, where water is an escape and mud keeps skin cool.

How does it send messages?

It barks a sharp warning, hums and purrs to stay in contact, and uses scent to mark plants.

What does it do when something changes?

When startled, the whole group rushes into the water, and it can hold its breath for minutes.

How does it learn?

Young ones follow adults to feeding spots and learn which sounds mean danger is coming.

How does it have babies?

A mother has two to eight babies, and several females take turns nursing the whole group's young.

What are its limits?

Without water close by, it cannot hide from big predators or cool off in the heat.

What does this teach us?

One animal watching the water's edge can keep the whole group safe.